

Rock Bass

Red-eyed ambusher around rock, wood, and shade

Ambloplites rupestris

Recognize it

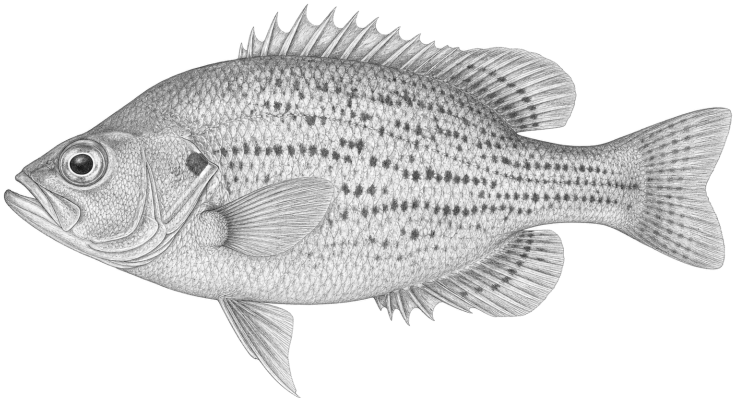
Stocky olive sunfish with red eye and rows of dark side spots.

Body	More elongate than bluegill; five to seven anal spines.
Mouth/fins	Mouth reaches beneath eye; continuous dorsal with strong spines.
Confusion	Warmouth has three anal spines and radiating dark cheek lines.

Lake role

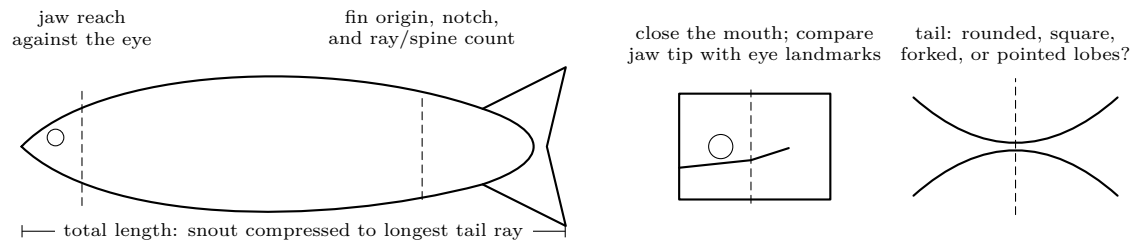
Where it belongs Rock, wood, docks, shade, and firm transitions.
Food and season Crayfish, insects, and small fish; often close to bottom or hard cover.

Identification plate



Original graphite portrait for this ChatGPT edition. Morphology reviewed against Wisconsin DNR species references.

Read the fish before naming it



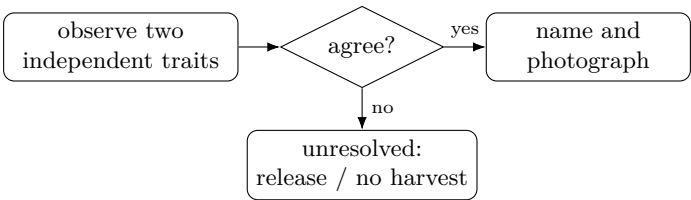
- 1. **Silhouette first.** Confirm the stocky but more elongate sunfish body and mouth reaching beneath the eye.
- 2. **Hard structure second.** Count five to seven anal spines with fins controlled safely.
- 3. **Markings last.** Use red eye and rows of side spots only after the spine count.

Intermediate questions

Before looking at the species name, answer aloud: *Where does the closed jaw end? Are dorsal sections joined or separate? What is the tail-lobe shape? Which mark is structural enough to survive poor light?* If two answers conflict, record “unresolved” and do not force the identification.

Confusion-pair gate

Candidate	Rock Bass
Nearest alternative	Warmouth has three anal spines and radiating dark cheek lines.
Required gate	Rock bass requires more than eye color: five-to-seven anal spines and the long mouth must agree.
Independent check	A ventrolateral fin photograph should preserve the anal-spine count and mouth-to-eye alignment.



Find it on these waters

Pine	Test rocky points, hard-bottom breaks, and shade where accessible.
North	Test wood, riprap, narrows, and firm spots beside weeds.
Evidence	The DNR lake records sometimes name only a broad group such as panfish. In that case this species is a candidate member, not verified individual presence. Confirm presence before targeting; treat locations as testable habitat hypotheses, not abundance findings.

Field evidence log

Date/time	Water + station	Depth/temp	Two observed traits	Habitat, lure, result
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Evidence threshold. One sighting is an observation, not an abundance claim. Repeat the same identification gate on another fish, retain a clear lateral photograph when lawful and safe, and note failed searches as carefully as catches. Repeated catches on the same hard cover support a station; red eye alone never closes identification.

Presentations

1. **Small jig.** Hop a compact plastic or hair jig through rock; pause in gaps.
2. **Live-bait float.** Suspend worm or small minnow beside cover, not inside the snag.
3. **Stop rule.** If only tiny fish bite, move to the next deeper hard edge.

On-water verification

After the first response, ask: *Did the fish, depth, cover, and bite match the prediction?* Repeat once. If the second result disagrees, return to search mode rather than explaining away the evidence.

HANDLING DECIDES THE OUTCOME

Beware dorsal and anal spines; wet hands and cradle the fish.

Harvest decision · 2026–27

Water-specific rule	Open all year; no minimum; rock/yellow/white bass daily bag unlimited on both lake pages.
Kitchen choice	Keep thicker mid-size fish that yield usable fillets; stop at the planned meal despite no daily limit.
Before the trip	Open the Wisconsin DNR water-specific regulation page for WBIC 779200 (Pine) or 850800 (North). Check the exact water, species, and date; the live rule controls if this dated sheet differs.

Keep only a fish you can use

Decide before the cast. Bring ice, stop fishing when the planned meal is secured, and use the species-specific cooking guide for dispatch, bone layout, and safe preparation. Large old predators are valuable spawners and generally carry more mercury than smaller fish.

Sources checked 2026-07-26. Wisconsin DNR lake fish records (Pine WBIC 779200; North WBIC 850800), Wisconsin's Fishes, Hook Your Catch, 2026–27 water-specific regulations, Catch-and-release Guidelines, and Eating Your Catch. Biological and tactical synthesis is editorial; it is not a current population survey.

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